GOA, THE GRAND OPPOSITION ALLIANCE

The Congress, hoping for a resurgence in Goa before the 2027 assembly election, floats an anti-saffron front. But the ground is shaky even before local body polls



and South Goa ZP polls. The two ZPs have 25 members each, and the BJP had swept 33 seats, nearly two-third of the total, leaving the Congress gasping at just four. It got a drubbing even in south Goa's Salcette taluka, which has a sizeable number of Catholics and Muslims and accounts for eight of Goa's 40 assembly segments. It won just three of Salcette's nine ZP seats. Overall, even Independents bagged seven seats.

But the Congress fancies better chances for itself in 2027. It feels the 2024 victory of partyman Viriato Fernandes from the South Goa Lok Sabha seat reflected growing discontent over controversial linear projects, joblessness and law and order. A united Opposition, it feels, will protect its flanks by preventing a split of the anti-incumbency vote—as in 2022, when the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and Trinamool Congress ate into its vote share.

BRUTUS INC.

But the pilot run has hit an air pocket. The GFP, its new GOA partner, has pulled an unpleasant surprise by inducting Isidore Fernandes, a four-term MLA, who defected from the Congress to the BJP in 2019. The victim of many splits since 2017, the Grand Old Party is understandably sensitive to reminders of that. In September 2022, eight of its 11 MLAs, led by Digambar Kamat and then leader of the opposition Michael Lobo, had defected to the BJP. This was after Congress candidates took an oath in a temple, church and mosque to not change loyalties post-elections! Kamat is now minister for public works.

"We have to be careful in choosing alliance partners... otherwise, they will join with the BJP later," says a Congress senior. He also flags the prickly issue of seat-sharing. The GFP is suggesting that 20 of the 50 ZP seats be reserved for the non-Congress duo: 10 for itself,

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE